



Figure 3: Commercial Break Tagging on MythBox



Figure 4: MythBox's Watch TV Interface

resolutions (720i and 1080i) is rather flaky at the moment.

One last hurdle is that if you have a DTH service, chances are your set-top box connects to your TV through component (Y/Pb/Pr) cables (3-plug adapters). Even if your TV tuner card supports this type of input, support on Linux is flaky, or even non-existent in some cases. Also, since there is no way to change channels using the computer—it must be done on the STB—you'll have trouble doing scheduled recordings. So I'd recommend connecting the STB separately — directly to the TV (keep the STB on A/V, while the computer is on HDMI).

Setting up the mammoth

First of all, you might try christening this media centre. XBMC 9.04.1 is codenamed Babylon, so you could try christening the PC Mesopotamia :-). Anyway, once you have set up the hardware, start up the PC and install Ubuntu 9.04 on it. It doesn't matter whether you are using 32- or 64-bit, but 64-bit should give better performance.

Something you might try doing is keeping three separate partitions and mounting them under `/XBMCVideos`, `/XBMCMusic` and `/XBMCPictures`, and then dumping your movies, songs and pictures into them, respectively. It keeps the stuff in one place, and that helps in organisation. Remember you won't be able to browse for files on these machines, you will only be able to see your media repositories (folders that you designate) and removable drives.

You'll need up to 60GB of `/tmp` space because in case your Blu-rays are encrypted, the entire disk has to be decrypted and copied over until you can watch it.

Once Ubuntu is installed, install the Nvidia drivers by typing the following command in a terminal:

```
sudo apt-get install nvidia-glx-180 nvidia-settings
```

After that, enable the drivers from **System** → **Administration** → **Hardware Drivers**, and reboot the system. You should now get the maximum resolution that your TV supports (hopefully 1080p). Bingo! The first segment of the project is complete.

Now install all the multimedia codecs by typing in the following:

```
sudo apt-get install gstreamer0.10-lame ffmpeg fluendo-mp3 \
gstreamer0.10-plugins-bad-ugly
```

That will pull in all native back-ends as well as the FFMPEG back-end (which enables use of libavcodec), so you can now play all media formats without exception.

Update all the software by running the following code.

```
sudo apt-get update && sudo apt-get upgrade
```

It's time for XBMC. Go to **System** → **Administration** → **Software Sources**. Switch to the **Third-Party Software** tab and press **Add**. Type in:

```
deb http://ppa.launchpad.net/jean-xbmc/jaunty-ppa/ubuntu jaunty main
```

You'll get a warning saying, "Since GPG keys were not found the packages downloaded from this repo cannot be verified." I don't really care about this so I don't add GPG keys; however, if you so wish, the details are at their PPA page.

Now press **Alt+F2** and type in "apt:xbmc" at the box. Get a cup of coffee while XBMC gets downloaded and installed.

Great! XBMC is now installed. Go to **Application** → **Sound & Video** → **XBMC Media Center** and watch it start up.

The first time might be a rather disappointing start, since XBMC is running windowed. Go to **Settings** → **Appearance** and then **Screen**, and change the resolution to your screen's resolution—either 720p or 1080p. That'll take care of things. If it doesn't, exit XBMC, press **Alt+F2** and run "xbmc -fs". That should sort out the problem.

The next thing to do is browse to **Music**, **Pictures** and **Videos**, and add the sources that were discussed earlier. Now, once you copy your media to these folders, you will be able to browse to them from the interface.

That's almost all. There're some small details left. Setting up LIRC is left to the user, however, as remote settings are unique for every model.